



REUTERS/PETER KEEP

DEVELOPED COUNTRIES HAVE UP TO 500 POLICEMEN FOR EVERY ONE LAKH PEOPLE; INDIA LAGS WAY BEHIND WITH 126.

MUMBAI'S ICONIC TAJ HOTEL SPEWS SMOKE AS TERROR CLOUDS INDIA'S HORIZON.

precedented in its scope and was a direct challenge to the authority of the Indian state. In the recent past there have been three such attacks with similar intent: the 2001 strike on the Indian Parliament, the 2002 storming of the Akshardham temple and the July 2005 attack on the Ramlala idol at Ayodhya.

While cowardly blasts in crowded areas increased in both their intensity and scope, it was these four attacks that had the capability of causing mayhem in the country. All of them had been meticulously planned and involved highly-motivated militants who were trained as commandos and had rehearsed their strikes, possibly with some local help. Yet the country's security set-up, especially its alphabetical soup of intelligence agencies, didn't seem to have learnt the lessons from past terror attacks. That's why the horror of Mumbai happened.

Boost intelligence

While there is a blame game on, the fact remains that the attack did happen and that intelligence was not acted upon. The three top intelligence units, the Intelligence Bureau (IB), tasked with internal intelligence, Research and

Analysis Wing (R&AW) for external intelligence and the Defence Intelligence Agency (DIA) work mostly in independent silos and are chary of co-operating with each other. Despite the formation of a Multi-Agency Coordinating Committee (MACC) two years ago to coordinate their work and share intelligence, officials admit it is far from effective. General V.P. Malik, former army chief, says, "It was shocking to see that no joint control command was set up in the conduct of the Mumbai operations. Demolish the bamboo walls and iron curtains created by the bureaucracy. Instead, have a system that allows fast track flow of grass-roots intelligence through different levels of sift-and-assess modes."

Former R&AW chief Girish Chandra Saxena who had headed a committee on intelligence reforms, which gave its report in 2001, said that most of its recommendations remained "on the anvil". Among various things, Saxena's report had recommended that at least 30,000 personnel should be engaged in field duty in the country's premier intelligence agency—the IB. The actual facts, however, are shocking. The total strength of the IB is 25,000, of which almost a third are drivers, peons and, administrative and